

Special Issue on

Sustainability Policy Backlash and the Role of Research

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Background and rationale

The profound social, economic, and technological transformation required to avert dangerous climate change was never going to be politically straightforward. Yet, the pace and scope of sustainability transformations have been made significantly more difficult by persistent and evolving forms of backlash and obstruction (Patterson 2022; Ekberg et. al 2022;). Despite nearly four decades of climate science consolidation since the establishment of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC), and despite the development of increasingly sophisticated technological and policy tools, progress toward effective climate mitigation and broader sustainability goals remains uneven and contested (Stoddard et. al 2021).

A growing body of research suggests that these shortcomings cannot be explained solely by technological barriers, insufficient policy design, or lack of scientific knowledge. Instead, organized and often well-resourced networks of actors actively resist, delay, dilute, or redirect sustainability policies (Roberts et. al 2025; Brown 2017; Brulle 2014). Fossil fuel corporations and allied industries, wealthy individuals, lobbying firms, think tanks, media outlets, and advocacy groups have used diverse strategies to maintain the status quo (Brulle and Roberts 2024; Farrell 2016; Dunlap and McCright 2011). These include shaping public discourse, financing misinformation campaigns, influencing electoral politics, funding strategic research initiatives, and engaging in regulatory and legal interventions.

Backlash and obstructionism are not new phenomena. They have accompanied environmental governance for decades. However, recent years have witnessed renewed and intensified forms of resistance. Economic crises, inflationary pressures, geopolitical instability, and the rise of right-wing populism in several countries have created fertile ground for anti-climate narratives (Haas et. al 2025; Bosetti et. al 2025; Patterson 2022). Climate and sustainability policies are increasingly framed as threats to jobs, living standards, competitiveness, sovereignty, or social cohesion (Bersalli et al. 2026; Brown and Spiegel 2019). In polarized political contexts, sustainability policy is sometimes bundled together with other contested issues such as migration, globalization, cultural identity or even democracy (Patterson 2025; Lockwood 2018; Marquardt et al. 2025).

At the same time, sustainability transformations are inherently contested processes (Köhler 2019; Geels 2011). Transitions reconfigure power relations, redistribute resources, and create both winners and losers. Conflicts are therefore not only the product of deliberate obstruction but also of distributive and procedural justice concerns (Newell et. al 2021; Jazuli et al., 2021). If transitions are perceived as unjust, imposed, or technocratic, they may generate legitimate grievances that can be mobilized into broader political backlash. Understanding the difference between strategic obstruction and socially rooted contestation is therefore crucial.

While research on climate obstruction has expanded significantly —particularly in North America and Europe— important gaps remain (Roberts et. al 2025). In particular, we know comparatively little about how backlash emerges across different sectors, governance levels, and socio-political contexts, and how it interacts with broader societal dynamics such as economic restructuring, digital media ecosystems,

religious mobilization, or armed conflict. Moreover, although much scholarship has examined the actors and mechanisms of obstruction, far less attention has been devoted to systematic analysis of responses to backlash —especially the role of research and researchers in counteracting it. This Special Issue seeks to address these gaps.

Aims of the special issue

The Special Issue has two overarching aims:

1. *To deepen understanding of the causes, actors, and mechanisms of sustainability policy backlash and obstruction across countries, sectors, and governance levels.*
2. *To explore responses to climate and sustainability backlash, with a particular focus on the role of research, researchers, and research institutions in counteracting, mitigating, or unintentionally reinforcing obstruction.*

By bringing together scholarship on backlash and the role of research, this Special Issue aims to move beyond diagnosing obstruction toward understanding how knowledge production, institutional design, and societal engagement can strengthen democratic and just sustainability transformations. We seek contributions that advance trans- and interdisciplinary debate, bridge empirical and conceptual insights, and critically reflect on the responsibilities and possibilities of research in times of contested transformation.

Key themes and research gaps

We particularly encourage submissions that address the identified research gaps and open questions. Other high-quality contributions that engage with the broader theme of this Special Issue will also be considered.

1. Right-wing populism and anti-democratic politics

While the link between RWP and Backlash has been well-established, anti-democratic politics nonetheless continue to inhibit just transitions. We invite contributions that move beyond simple correlations between populist parties and climate skepticism, and instead unpack the mechanisms through which anti-democratic politics inhibit just transitions.

- Through which political mechanisms do right-wing populist actors translate anti-elite, nationalist, or sovereignty-based narratives into concrete policy obstruction
- How do populist discourses reshape the framing of climate policy (e.g., as technocratic imposition, foreign interference, or urban elite project)
- What is the role of digital media ecosystems and alternative information networks in sustaining backlash.
- How do opposition parties, civil society actors, and research institutions navigate climate governance under conditions of shrinking democratic space.

2. Strategy effectiveness and policy process dynamics

While numerous actors—including NGOs, journalists, academics, and climate-concerned businesses—work to expose obstruction and counter misinformation, the effectiveness of these strategies remains underinvestigated. We are particularly interested in studies that:

- Assess the impact of different counter-obstruction strategies.
- Examine combinations of strategies over time.

- Analyze how interventions differ across stages of the policy cycle (agenda-setting, formulation, implementation, evaluation).
- Compare national or sectoral contexts to identify transferable lessons.

3. Labor unions and just transition politics

Labor unions play a pivotal role in shaping debates on industrial restructuring and just transition. Yet, their role in either blocking or advancing climate policies remains insufficiently understood. We invite studies exploring:

- How unions in carbon-intensive industries position themselves in climate debates.
- The conditions under which unions support or resist climate policies.
- The evolving meaning of “just transition” in policy negotiations.
- Cross-sectoral comparisons of labor mobilization in sustainability governance.

4. The role of researchers and research institutions

Research plays an important role in sustainability transitions. On the one hand, scientists and scholars have been central to identifying climate risks, developing policy instruments, and supporting evidence-based decision-making. On the other hand, research institutions can also become sites of contestation, politicization, or strategic influence. Open questions include:

- What roles do researchers play in counteracting misinformation and obstruction
- How effective are transdisciplinary and co-creative approaches (e.g., real-world laboratories, community sustainability councils, participatory transition arenas) in reducing backlash or building societal legitimacy
- How do funding structures shape research agendas in sustainability governance
- How and why do corporations, trade associations, and other actors fund academic research, and what are the implications for knowledge production
- Under what conditions does research contribute to “public inoculation” against misinformation, and when does it fail?

We are particularly interested in studies examining the interaction between academic knowledge production, public debate, and political processes.

5. Religion and moral authority

Religious actors can mobilize support for climate action but may also oppose or question sustainability policies. Research on religion and climate obstruction remains limited. Contributions could address:

- How religious narratives justify, reinterpret, or deny the need for climate action.
- The connections between religious networks, political actors, and economic interests.
- Comparative studies of faith-based mobilization in support of or against sustainability policies.
- The moral framing of climate justice within different religious traditions.

6. Arts, culture, and narrative contestation

Backlash is not only institutional but also cultural. Narratives, symbols, and emotional framing shape public perceptions of sustainability transitions. We encourage contributions on:

- The role of arts and culture in counteracting misinformation and polarization.

- Cultural narratives that reinforce or undermine climate obstruction.
- The effectiveness of storytelling, visual arts, and cultural interventions in building social legitimacy for sustainability policies.

7. Obstruction and backlash in the Global South

To date, much of the scholarship on climate obstruction has focused on the United States and Europe. However, socio-political dynamics in the Global South differ significantly in terms of state capacity, development trajectories, informal economies, resource dependence, colonial legacies, and exposure to climate impacts. Possible questions include:

- What role do state-owned enterprises play in enabling or resisting decarbonization
- Under what conditions does climate policy trigger grassroots resistance rooted in livelihood insecurity
- How do historical injustices and colonial extraction shape perceptions of “green” interventions
- How does the concept of “just transition” travel and transform across Global South contexts
- Do external conditionalities fuel nationalist backlash
- How do governments strategically use climate justice arguments in international negotiations
- What typologies of obstruction are adequate for Global South contexts
- How can transdisciplinary research better capture local perspectives and avoid epistemic dominance.

Types of contributions

We welcome:

- Comparative cross-country studies
- Sector-specific analyses (e.g., energy, transport, agriculture, finance)
- Theoretical and conceptual advancements
- Mixed-method and quantitative analyses of networks and influence
- Transdisciplinary research drawing on collaboration between academia and practice
- Studies that critically reflect on the role of research itself.

Timeline and conditions

The submission window for this Special Issue is **April to November 2026**.

- **April 2026** – Submission portal opens
- **November 2026** – Final deadline for manuscript submission
- **Rolling review process** – Manuscripts will be reviewed as they are received

After submission, manuscripts will undergo an initial editorial screening by the Guest Editors in collaboration with the Editor-in-Chief. Selected manuscripts will then proceed to a double-blind peer review process, in line with the journal’s standard procedures. Selection of articles based on: (i) Relevance to the theme of sustainability policy backlash and the role of research, (ii) Theoretical and/or empirical rigor, (iii) Contribution to interdisciplinary and transdisciplinary scholarship, (iv) Originality and clarity of argument.

SSPP is an open access journal. Accepted articles are therefore subject to an Article Processing Charge (APC). In principle, the APC must be covered by the authors’ affiliated institutions or research funding bodies. However, in exceptional cases —particularly for authors based in the Global South without

access to publication funding —RIFS may provide partial or full financial support, subject to availability and prior consultation with the Guest Editors.

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